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Shelly Berg

Pianist Shelly Berg was born in Cleveland, Ohio on August 18, 1955. He majored in music at the University of Houston. Currently he is the Chair of Jazz Studies at USC and is Past President of IAJE. Shelly has composed and arranged charts for numerous commercials, film soundtracks and pop groups, and finds time to perform and record with his own ensembles.

Shelly was interviewed in Scottsdale, Arizona on April 15, 2000, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Scottsdale, Arizona. My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Shelly Berg with me at the festival, and you seem to be a guy who wears a lot of different hats.

SB: Yeah, my life is about hats. Yeah. Educator, doing a fair bit of composing and scoring and traveling around and playing, and so yeah, it's a juggling act.

MR: Do you favor one over the other?

SB: It's an interesting thing. I think when I look at myself in the mirror in the morning I see a jazz piano player. I think that that's how I define myself. But if you think of the playing, the teaching and the scoring maybe being the order of fulfillment, if you flip it upside down that's the pay scale. So it's just one of those interesting things about life.

MR: What's on the top of the pay scale?

SB: The scoring job, in terms of the money per hours.

MR: Is that right?

SB: For instance if you're doing a network 30-second spot for a commercial, it may take you two hours to score the whole thing, and yet the pay can be a lot. Or working doing an orchestration for a rock star or something like that, per hour, that's probably the highest in terms of pay of the things that I do.

MR: Great. We'll have to talk more about that. At what point in your young life I guess, did it seem like music was going to be your thing?

SB: At my earliest recollection.

MR: Yeah.

SB: No I mean literally my earliest recollection is that music was going to be my thing. I don't recall a time in my life ever that music wasn't going to be my thing. I started picking out tunes at the piano when I was a toddler. And my parents came in when I was about five one day and I was playing "Alley Cat" with two hands. And so they decided it was time for lessons. So it's always been me.

MR: This begs a trivia question. You might be one of the few people who knows who the guy who recorded "Alley Cat" is.

SB: Oh no. I wasn't able to read the liner notes at that age.

MR: All right. I'll tell you later. It's an interesting name. So they recognized your talent?

SB: Yeah.

MR: Did they help you out in that regard?

SB: Yeah, my dad is an avocational jazz trumpet player. And he was also a classical French horn player. So the music was always around me. There were always jam sessions at my house when I was a kid and if people were in off the road they usually ended up at our house a jam session and dinner. So yeah, they were very encouraging.

MR: Where was home?

SB: At that time it was Cleveland, Ohio. And I think by the time I was ten or eleven my dad had pretty well scoped out that I was a potential live-in accompanist for his jazz trumpet.

MR: Oh, okay.

SB: So he was bringing me along quickly. That was good.

MR: Yeah. Do you recall the first time you played out?

SB: Oh yeah. I started to play out doing shows and things when I was ten or eleven doing little paid gigs just kind of playing things that I'd worked out. And then by the time I was thirteen I was trying to go to jam sessions with my dad, and getting kicked off the stand. You know they'd let me play a half of a tune or a tune and then say now go, you're done. But by the time I was fifteen I was in at the jam sessions I was playing.

MR: Well how did you make the transition from just playing what was on the page to expanding that, to comping and all that?

SB: All right, well when I was about ten or eleven my dad, as I said, he was figuring out that this was somebody that he might be able to play tunes with some day. So he started showing me basic chords and — don't ask me why, the first tune he taught me was "That's All."

MR: That's a bit of a challenge.

SB: Yeah. Well he taught me the first three chords, basically playing up from F minor, G minor, A minor and just back down. And I did that for a while, then he taught me [scats], so my mother must have gone crazy for about two weeks, I just played that up and down the piano, the first four bars of "That's All" until he finally taught me [scats], and I got that other chord, and that was the next couple of weeks. So it was a slow process. That was the beginning. As I said there was always music in the house. My dad, whenever he was home there was always a record on. He had a big, huge collection and so he was sitting me down with Art Tatum and Oscar Peterson, Bill Evans and Bud Powell and Red

down and saying, "Listen to this, what are you hearing," and really just mentoring me along. And he still does.

MR: Great. Music college was in your future from that time on then?

SB: Yeah. I studied classical piano all my life and ended up with a master's degree in classical piano and conducting from the University of Houston. And I still practice, and I really try to teach all my jazz piano students to love classical music and understand what it can mean to them as jazz pianists.

MR: You're in good company then because Roland Hanna just said the same thing.

SB: Really?

MR: Yeah. He talked about the importance of being able to recognize what they did with harmonies and how they wrote for piano.

SB: Well there are just so many thousands, endless kinds of sounds and colors you can get out of a piano and I think working on classical literature is a really focused way to get to that. What I notice with my students who don't work on classical music is their hands aren't very supple, especially their left hand. It kind of looks like a club. And you want them to develop that beautiful suppleness to their hands and then you know that they have a freedom to really express themselves.

MR: Yeah. When did you first get into composing/arranging?

SB: Well my first professional composing gig was when I was I think twelve. There was a synagogue in Cleveland that was opening a new sanctuary, and I got commissioned to compose a piece for a youth orchestra to play at the opening. So once I figured out about transpositions, everything was fine. The first read through was a little rough.

MR: Uh ho. You were into atonality already.

SB: Yeah. Schoenberg had nothing on me at that point except for intention.

[pause]

MR: You need to stop? What's happening? Oh, okay.

MR: But that must have been a monumental thing to do for a first orchestration I would think, when you're twelve?

SB: I think you don't know it's hard yet. I'd played a lot of classical piano and I kind of had some Alberti textures and boom-chuck-chuck kind of textures from the pieces that I played and I think I was just emulating kind of what I knew with a nice little Jewish-sounding theme, at least it seemed like to me.

MR: Cool. Does that score still exist?

SB: Yes it does.

MR: All right.

SB: In all of its pencil-written glory.

SB: The same. I have a mini-studio in Hollywood, and I use Finale and I use sequencing and sample, all the gear. But when it comes to orchestrating, it's me at a table with the score, a pencil in my hand. And the best way I can describe it is orchestrating or composing for orchestra is kind of you descend into a world where you can hear everything. I think at its best you don't want to be at a piano, you don't want to be hearing it back on a synthesizer. It takes fifteen, twenty minutes at least, to decompress yourself down to that world when suddenly you're hearing everything. And then once you're in that space hopefully the phone doesn't ring.

MR: I was just going to say you have to isolate yourself pretty well.

SB: Right. And that's how I write. And I can write really quickly once I get to that place because then the piece kind of happens.

MR: Wow. That's really interesting.

SB: Yeah, it's an interesting feeling.

MR: Do you think the tools that are available today — how should I say this — don't foster that kind of ability?

SB: It's a concern. It's great in that you can immediately hear in terms of trial and error and learning to hear and getting to hear back what you've written. It's a great tool, with the caveat that you're not really hearing back what you've written. And chances are it may sound a whole lot better or a whole lot worse in a real environment. So there's certainly some use to it. I find in the industry now everybody wants a full demo of any orchestra piece you write. And you can get it to sound so good that they think it's what it's going to sound like and yet it isn't and there's a really worry there. Because they might not quite get it from the demo and yet it sounds convincing enough that they think they're hearing the real thing. So it's fraught with those pitfalls. But yeah, I think that — you know there was an interesting column, I think it was in *Jazz Times* a couple of years ago. And what it said I agree with, and basically it said that technology makes it possible for everyone to create the atmosphere of great music. You can put on your Will Lee bass loop and your Peter Erskine drum loop and lock up the BPM and you've got that, and then you've got the greatest sampled sounds and this and that and the other, and you can basically put something together that the sounds sonically are first rate. That doesn't even begin to speak to what you are as a composer or what aptitude you have for that. But you've now created the atmosphere that you're doing it. And I guess the same could be said in graphics, with computer graphics and all those kinds of things. There is difference between artists who can really draw something and somebody who can just merge a bunch of stuff off of a computer program. So in some ways an interesting dichotomy has happened. With the explosion of media kinds of outlets, there is much more opportunity

years ago could never have been in this business. And it becomes hard to separate them out.

MR: That's true. If you go and you search CD Now and everyone has a web site, which you can say is a good thing because everyone has the opportunity. But how do you find out who belongs there?

SB: Right.

MR: I suppose in a sense the people who were in it before this technological explosion can tend to feel a little threatened unless they keep up with it.

SB: And it's difficult to keep up with it. If you buy the right magazines what it tells you every week is that you're behind now. Buy this.

MR: And it's hopeless. Wow.

SB: So but every time I sit down at a piano, it's a technology that hasn't changed in a long time.

MR: Yeah.

SB: And it's still revealing new things to me every day.

MR: Interesting. And these kind of situations probably reveal new things too, playing with any combination of people.

SB: It's fascinating. And I think some really great energies can happen. Some people, if they're traveling with their own bands lament well it's all going to be a jam session. But it's a very special kind of a jam session at a festival like this. And already today some really amazing things have happened. So I love it.

MR: Right. It doesn't look like anybody is out to make anybody else look bad, like there's a group thing.

SB: That's not the vibe here at all, as a matter of fact everybody is very encouraging. When I played my first solo today and Herb Ellis went like this, I thought okay, that made my year. He was either very angry or try to figure that out. No, everybody is pulling for everybody here, trying to — certainly as a rhythm section player my job is to, I say that what I do is kind of like the background to a painting, and the foreground is the soloist. So if the soloist is the Pope I try not to be hell. So I try to be the background that really puts it in its best light. So I think everybody in the rhythm section is working with that in mind. It certainly sounds like that way to me.

MR: Would you consider some years as dues paying years in your career so far?

SB: They've all been dues paying.

MR: They all are and they probably will remain that way?

SB: In some ways. I think if you talk to a hundred people you'll have a hundred different paths to getting where they are. I got married on my nineteenth birthday for the first time

worked my way playing six nights a week top 40 and country music. Graduated college and took a job teaching at a community college so that I could get out of working every night at a wedding reception band. And so I couldn't afford to take very many jazz gigs because I could make more money with the wedding reception band. So that was a lot of dues paying. I learned a lot and I love music so I always enjoyed it, but it wasn't really until I moved to L.A. nine years ago that I started becoming seriously a jazz piano player. And a lot of that was precipitated by Bill Watrous, who came and was the guest artist in the late 80s at the community college where I taught in Texas. And the students were saying, "Oh Mr. Watrous you should hear Mr. Berg our director play." And so on the concert he said, "You've got to play," and I said no, this is about the students. And he said, "No, no, just one song, just play with me." So I did and he hired me. So he really encouraged me to move to Los Angeles and my kids were getting older and life was changing and so these last nine years I've started to really be a jazz piano player.

MR: Well that's great. He's a nice guy.

SB: He's been great, a true friend and mentor.

MR: You mentioned writing for Hollywood and the studios. How did that come about? Do you need to meet people? Is there a way like —

SB: My standard line is it's a business of relationships, and all it takes is one. That's another interesting thing is when you read interviews of film composers, well I was playing in some rock band and so-and-so became a fan and I did their student film and then they made it, and I mean it's never I graduated from film scoring school and made phone calls and I got hired. Or they came and recruited me like lawyers. It's totally relationships. Every cool job I've ever gotten has been from some convoluted path. And what I encourage my students to do, and people I talk to, is just be out there, be a musician, be playing, be where you can meet people. Because you never know what's going to lead to what. I orchestrated an album for the pop band Chicago because the co-leader, Jim Panko, the trombone player is a big Bill Watrous fan and always came out to hear the band, and heard the orchestrations I did with Bill and said we're going to do an album with a big band and I want you to write all the charts. And I'm going sure, like this will really happen. And it did. So it's definitely a business of relationships. Some of the movie things I've done have come from rock things I've done, and the same rock producers have gotten involved in the movie industry and I've gotten in kind of that way. So that's how it goes. There's no path.

MR: Is it a high pressure situation, writing for films?

SB: Yeah, it's an interesting thing, I had to orchestrate an hour's worth of music for a Warner Brothers film in about two weeks, all while I'm teaching and playing and doing all the

a year. And you wonder what all that was about. I think that the bigger the medium actually the less pressure in some ways. The most pressure is in commercials, in that little thirty second spot. I think advertising agencies, agencies rent offices and hire staff just for that one client and if they lose that client the bottom drops out. Tremendously charged and they try to disperse that pressure to everyone they work with. And then television seems to be next and then movies, once people have made it to that level it seems like they have more of a comfort level with what they're doing. And for me it actually seemed you were a little less second guessed in movies than you are in television, and a lot less than you are in the commercial world. So it's interesting. But in all those things you're dealing with people who probably are sticking their nose a little farther into your thing than what they have any business.

MR: Wow you just anticipated my question. Because you're usually dealing with non-musicians when you're doing commercials.

SB: Right.

MR: And do you have trouble trying to bring to reality what they're describing to you?

SB: Sometimes. You can think you're right on the wavelength and you're totally wrong. It's gotten to where sometimes I'll just say can you give me an example of something that's what you mean. Because they can say something and the words that they are using evoke a certain thing but it's really the opposite of what they want. There's a famous film scoring story of a well known composer, who the director said for this one cue, give me Debussy, I want Debussy.

MR: Yeah.

SB: Have you heard this one?

MR: No. I have not.

SB: It's a true story. He gets on the scoring stage and he's got LaMer nailed. And it's gorgeous and the textures, and the cellos with five different parts. And he finishes and the orchestra is all tapping their bows, and the director walks up to him and says, "You know, I hate it. I just hate it." So at that point the director said, "I want my mother" I think that's the quote, that's what he said, I want my mom. But he got with the director and what the composer found out was that the director really wanted Mozart. He just threw out the first classical name he could think of, which was Debussy. But the sound he had in mind was Mozart.

MR: It's all the same thing, isn't it?

SB: Yeah. So the second T.V. series that I wrote for I did a children's series for two years on ABC. And the very first episode there was a turtle in the episode. The kid in the episode had a pet and I wrote this little piece of music. And the producer comes in and I thought

turtle music and that's really an aquatic turtle." I thought she was joking. I said, "Well you had it in an terrarium, you faked me out here, I thought it was a land turtle. She was serious. I had to change the music and somehow figure out what she meant by water turtle music.

MR: It's really fascinating to watch the trends that commercials seem to jump on. Like I've been noticing lately a lot of commercials that have a female vocalist imitating Sheryl Crow. And this seems to be the hot thing. And I wonder how long that will last, until something else comes along.

SB: Well it's because one of them worked. And that's the big thing in the media these days. Anything that works, let's just do that because it's already proved itself. And it can be frustrating when you're composing because it puts you in a very narrow box. But it's a gig.

MR: Yeah, it's a gig. Drop some names on me. What are some of the rock bands, let's see you did Chicago.

SB: Well I'm so pleased that I got a Grammy nomination for working with Kiss.

MR: Oh my, is that right?

SB: Played piano and orchestrated for Kiss on their recent "Psycho Circus" album. And Gene Simmons actually is an interesting guy and when we were working with him I had a writing partner and we asked him how are the rehearsals going for the tour? He said, "What does it matter?" He said, "We can suck and fifty thousand people will come to every concert." He said, "The problem with you jazz musicians is you want to play good for seventy-five dollars."

MR: Great quote. Thank you, Gene.

SB: I worked with Richard Marks on a couple of albums, who is a great pop star. I worked on an album for a guy named Elliot Smith that *Billboard* magazine named the number two album of the year last year, it was a really great alternative songwriter. So you never know. I mean I've worked with Mickey Gilley in country music and I've kind of worked with a wide variety, there's some Japanese, I do a lot of work for Japanese superstars and they've got a whole sound. And I love that because this one guy I work with typically uses 80 or 90 piece orchestras on Japanese rock tunes. So it's like doing a film score.

MR: Do you usually get the assignment musically after the fact, after they've laid down most of the tune and then, okay, now what can you do with this?

SB: Right. Typically that's true. Depending. I mean obviously if you're doing a scoring thing then you're wide open but when you're working with rock bands typically they've laid down tracks and then it's your job to come in. So it's an interesting kind of a straight jacket and yet you're still trying to create something.

MR: I would guess, and sometimes it must be a challenge to — how can anything be put over this? That would be my sense.

SB: Especially when it's heavy metal and then there's a ninety piece orchestra.

MR: Yeah. There's so much going on. Well. It's a challenge.

SB: It's another one of those challenges and one time this Japanese guy that I work with had a kind of a power metal ballad thing. And he said I'd like to do an alternate version with just the lead vocal and fifty strings, and write whatever you want. And so now all I had was a lead vocal and I wasn't married to the chord progression. And there was even about a twelve or sixteen bar guitar solo in the middle where now there was nothing. And I wrote like for Verkärte Nacht, Schoenberg, for those sixteen bars. And the guy loved it, and he released that instead of the original version, with totally different harmonies, and it went to number one in Japan. So that was about the one time I ever got a clean plate.

MR: Do you do all your own business as far as contracts and all that kind of thing?

SB: Yeah I have a partner and he kind of manages the business of the office so I'm not having to fill out too many contracts or copy any parts or hire players. So it works out well because he's a great musician too but he's also willing to do that stuff.

MR: I get tired thinking about your schedule I guess.

SB: Yeah I mean I am the Chair of Jazz Music in the Thornton School at University of Southern California and that's kind of a full time job too. But that's a great job. I love it. We have wonderful students and incredible faculty. It's a real Who's Who.

MR: Well you must have an answer for people who say you can't teach jazz.

SB: I definitely have an answer for that. You can teach jazz. We must teach jazz. You can't teach talent. There's no question about that. But you can teach jazz. And what we've discovered is it's a language. And the way to teach a language is on different levels at the same time. You wouldn't want to take a language just out of a textbook, you wouldn't want to just learn it conversationally and not be literate in it. So the great thing about a university is it's an environment where if it's done well you can really do both. You can mentor on that kind of visceral, conversational level, and you can also then come in after the fact and teach the literacy, which I think is important.

MR: By that do you mean teaching some amount of learning the craft by ear and by gut? And then following that up or at the same time teaching chords.

SB: I think it's better when you follow it up. I think that's the way we learn to speak. We were talking for a long time before we were diagramming sentences.

MR: Well I really like that idea, and especially, I mean because I've seen other instances where people try to do it the opposite way, teaching all the vocabulary, the chord structure and everything and then trying to apply it. And I don't know if it works.

SB: I think it can be overload. You've got all this information and you just feel okay I have this information, what in the world am I supposed to be doing with this? It means nothing to me if my students can write every seven to third resolution for every chord change but then you play a chord and say sing the seven to third and they can't hear it. So I'd rather they could sing the seven to third even if they didn't know how to write it just yet, and find it on their horn and learn to play it, and learn, not only how to play it, but how does it feel? How does the tension release of that feel? What's the feeling you get by holding the seventh? What's the feeling you get by releasing it to the third? How can you work with that? How can you play with that? How can you create something with that? And then we'll get around to analyzing it so maybe you can use it as a writer, use it in other situations, use it more fully, figure out other things that go with it. So I think that's what we're trying to do where I teach and in a lot of places.

MR: Does everybody on your faculty seem to share that basic philosophy?

SB: We have a lot of different philosophies but the thing is, the sum total of that ends up being that philosophy. So we have John Clayton, a world class bassist and composer, who says to his students, "Burn your fake books. I never want to see a fake book in your presence. I want you to go out on the gigs and just use your ear and learn to hear and I don't want you to know what the changes are, I just want you to be able to sing them and be able to find them." And that's a crash course in developing your ear. And on the other side we have Tom Mason who is a brilliant jazz pedagogue, who is ripping it apart and analyzing it for the students. The composite is they get the whole thing.

MR: What's the future for those graduates?

SB: Well that's the million dollar question. I'm glad I teach in L.A., in Los Angeles, because I think there's a lot of opportunity for my students and I've got a brilliant jazz piano student who got his master's degree who is touring with Christina Aguilera right now, and another brilliant jazz piano student who's touring with Big Bad Voodoo Daddy, and another one who's recording with Anthony Wilson and Ronald Muldrew and a bunch of guys like that and he's making it in the hard core jazz scene. Three of my recent graduates. So I think that it's important to realize that there's a big world of music out there and become the best musician that you can be and if you're a great jazz musician, you're the best musician you can be. And don't shun any opportunities. Don't shun the chance to do something that's a little outside the box for jazz because I think I'm living proof, I have a wonderful career in music and I get to play great music also, at times like this. So I think I get the best of all the worlds but so few are going to make it to that pinnacle where they can make their living all the time exclusively playing their instrument and jazz. So our methodology at USC is to help them see that there is a future

I could never explain to them. So it's fun. I hear from my former students and we always have a talk their senior year, where they have this look of panic, of what am I going to do. And they seek me out, they come to my office, now what? And I always tell them, I give them a little advice, talk to them, but I say basically I'm going to see you a year after you graduate and you'll be well into what you're doing. And that invariably is the case I think. They come back a year after they graduate and they're into whatever it is. And some good percentage of them are mostly playing and mostly playing jazz. But a lot of them have just found other things and they still play their jazz, like I do. I'm not on the road every week just playing jazz. I suppose I'd like to be maybe, I guess you've got to be careful what you wish for. But I could see at some point in my life doing that.

MR: I can see your partner calling you up and saying, "Did you wish for something last week because the phone stopped ringing, now what's going on here?"

SB: Well I'd be even more careful about wishing for doing that full time. Because they I couldn't play at all.

MR: Well I like what you just said basically about students having to be versatile or having to have the kind of mindset where they're willing to be versatile. Because if you said there's opportunities out there, they might not always be in that specific niche that the student thought.

SB: Right. And I'll talk to a young, talented student and they're out there, a tenor player, and he'll say, "Well I'm going to go to New York because I know there's a lot of great players out there, but I'm going to rise to the top, I'm going to be the one that makes it." And you don't want to rain on their parade because they might. But I find it easy enough to say you know there's only one Joshua Redman and he's smart enough to have a degree from Harvard.

MR: Ah. Isn't it nice to have someone you can pull on to make that example.

SB: But how many other people are in that world where they can just, a young player, make their living playing jazz? I hope it will be more and more. I hope that — there are kinds of music that enjoy ubiquity and yet they're obscure at the same time, and jazz is that way. It's everywhere and yet people aren't necessarily paying for it.

MR: Interesting, yeah. And you look at the audience that's here and I mean these people are so into it, yet they're all up there in age, and you're going to wonder like are there going to be replacements.

SB: I don't worry about that so much because what symphony orchestras discovered, they worried about that too, that the audience is getting older and they're going to just disappear. And what they discovered is that it's not that it's just this group of people in that age group, as people move into that age group their tastes change. So it's always

kinds of music. But I don't think that that's the total answer and I would like to see a younger demographic for jazz. I play at a jazz club in L.A. that is families and young people and college kids, and it's straight ahead jazz and the place is packed every night. So that's a hopeful sign. But if we can find a way to make people aware that that thing that's all around them, that jazz thing is something that they can be consumers of, we can do a lot better. And I was president of the International Association of Jazz Educators for two years. And that's an organization that's dedicated to building a new jazz audience from the ground up. And the idea is if we can get in and teach the teachers, teach the general music teachers who never had jazz in college to love jazz and expose their students to it. We've started an artist outreach network with IAJE to get the labels — well you've got these guys on tour, let's get on tour let's get them into elementary schools. Michael Brecker showing a kid what a saxophone sounds like and try to get those values imprinted early. We can build a bigger niche for jazz. And the jazz industry is getting smarter. They've been — country music really took off when they started the CMA and they had their own advocacy group that all the labels paid in to and they started the Country Music Awards and they created a higher profile, and then country really took off and became a much bigger piece of the market. Well jazz is now starting to do the same thing. And it's in its infancy but that has now, an organization like that has begun with label support. And who knows? Maybe over the next ten years that group will do, in some small measure, what CMA did for country music. So it'll be nice. It could be better, maybe I'll have more gigs and my students will have more gigs, and there'll be more audience.

MR: You don't see too much jazz in the video format on T.V. I suppose that would help too. In a sense I wish it wasn't necessary because I think jazz is enough for your imagination. But I suppose you have to do whatever you can.

SB: Yeah you have to play the hand that's dealt. And you can't ignore the habits of a generation. You can't turn a blind eye to the way that they're going to receive and are receiving their entertainment. So there has to be a changeover into that. We must have jazz videos, and I think BET is trying to accomplish that in some way with their Bet On Jazz channel. So pieces are there. There's an infrastructure that's in place it just remains to be seen what's going to be done with it. It's improving, I can feel that. I think that there's a greater awareness of jazz and we're starting to see jazz as an accouterment to a lifestyle that, if you're a little more sophisticated, maybe you're out of your twenty-something thing, and you enjoy a good glass of port and this kind of thing, well there's jazz then. You start to see that and then I think that's certainly speaks to the appeal of Diana Krall and some of — you know she sold over a million CDs. Well that means that

there's some demographic now that's significant and is accepting this as a part of their lifestyle.

MR: I think of John Pizzarelli in that vein. He's found a niche there I think.

SB: Yeah and there's a whole hipster thing starting to happen with Kurt Elling, Patricia Barber, people like that, that this melding of kind of a hipster appearance, a Hollywood kind of swinger's look with jazz, that also could be an interesting trend for us.

MR: Who are the jazz musicians that you aspired to, or just thought that these are the guys man.

SB: It's a long list. At the center of it all for me growing up was Oscar Peterson. That's why it was so gratifying to do this album with Ray Brown and that big band tribute album, because that was the motivation. And there was a time I was even going back and forth, classical music, jazz music, what do I want to do. And in one kind of astounding week, Vladimir Horowitz came out of one of his retirements and played in Houston where I was living, and Oscar Peterson came through and did a solo recital in the same hall. And I left the Vladimir Horowitz concert so enthused about practicing and so excited. But I left the Oscar Peterson concert saying that's what I want to be. And I was about 17 at the time. That's when it really hit home that I'm going to be a jazz musician, and I'll always love my classical music but this is it. But growing up my dad exposed me to a lot. He had all the original 78s, Savoy and Dial, all the Charlie Parker and Lucky Thompson and all those great — Don Byas and Coleman Hawkins "Body and Soul" he had all that stuff on 78s. And my dad is a trumpet player so he had probably every Miles Davis album. And he was giving me big dosages of Oscar Peterson and Art Tatum. But I think to this day maybe my favorite player in history is Cannonball Adderley.

MR: I'm just looking at Tim because he knows that Cannonball is my guy.

SB: Really?

MR: Well let's talk about Cannonball Adderley.

SB: Let's forget all those other guys. Milt Jackson way up there too.

MR: Well I'm just so pleased you said that because that's how I feel too but I'm wondering why.

SB: Oh I know why.

MR: Okay.

SB: I know why. Because he's the perfect culmination of every attribute. Impeccable technique, impeccable time, as sophisticated harmonically and melodically as anybody of his day, and yet so incredibly soulful and bluesy. And you put all those things together and there's just no other player for me that's ever synergized all those things so well. And nobody's ever swung any more than that.

MR: I like this guy. Well said. I feel the same exact way. I'm a saxophone player, so he just like, he had it all. He had the tone, it was so vibrant and uplifting.

SB: Oh absolutely.

MR: And then, put on top of the fact that he could talk to people.

SB: Absolutely so.

MR: Which not everybody can.

SB: He was a school teacher.

MR: Yeah.

SB: And had his own talk show at a time when there weren't many African-Americans that had network talk shows.

MR: Yes. I've got to get a copy of those things. I wonder if they exist.

SB: I think Roy McCurdy, who I play with a fair bit in Los Angeles, has quite a few of those things.

MR: Oh, thanks for the lead.

SB: Because he played for that show and talks about it quite a bit.

MR: All right. I'll be giving Roy a call. I didn't know that until a while ago, someone else told me that, I was very fascinated by that. But you know the band he had in the 60s with Joe Zawinul and I mean that's it.

SB: We have some of those CDs in — both Julieann, my wife and I, in our cars we have Cannonball CDs in both our cars right now from that era. So wherever we're going we can always get right to it.

MR: Isn't that great.

SB: I love the Nancy Wilson/Cannonball.

MR: That's the one album — you know you do the thing about well if you're going to be on the beach— that's on my list.

SB: We're going to be on the desert island, right?

MR: Isn't it curious if you buy the CD of that, they rearranged the tunes. And you'll find it very annoying. Because on the album they have instrumental, vocal, instrumental. Well what they did on the CD is they put all the vocals, and then they put all the instrumentals.

SB: It sounds like two different CDs.

MR: Yeah. And you get so used to hearing the one tune end and you know what the key's going to be for the next. And I have to program it the way it used to be. But that is great. Well you have good taste.

SB: Likewise.

MR: What's on the docket for you in the very near future? Writing assignments?

SB: Yeah, I'm doing some writing. I just wrapped up a couple of cool television projects. We

you never know what the phone's going to ring, and so I've got some more of the Japanese rock things to do and I'm doing a project with an opera singer who wants to do an orchestral album of songs. So it's just — if the door's open, interesting things come in. But I don't really gauge my life on the writing projects. To me it's what's coming up. I'm getting to play the Norway jazz cruise with my trio, so that's what's exciting for me, and I'm going to be working on my next CD this summer and there's three singers that I work with who are all wonderful who I'm doing CDs with this summer as well. And hopefully Bill Watrous and I will be doing another album soon. So I hope to be in the studio playing lots of jazz over the next six or seven months.

MR: Wow. You must have a couple of different calendars to make sure that you're in the right place at the right time with the right hat on.

SB: That's the hardest part. It's really the hardest part. You don't want to end up with a feeling that you're not quite nailing it, not quite taking care of business for the university or for the writing office or for the playing or for the family. So that's really the hardest part, because I don't want to disappoint in any of those areas, so I'm constantly trying to figure out that balance.

MR: Do you have any nonmusical hobbies or anything? I ask that because I don't and I just wondered if there's something that gets you out of that.

SB: See there's nothing that's more refreshing to me than to practice the piano. So whatever I've been doing, the best diversion would be to sit down and play. I do work out, I like to exercise, I think to do what I do and do it well it's a good idea to be in pretty good shape. And if I get a chance to play some softball or throw a football around, I love sports. But I haven't played golf in 17 years I think. I can't imagine spending four hours doing anything — if I had those hours I should be at the piano. I couldn't live with myself. So yeah I don't have any regular hobby. I'm lucky in that what I love to do best is what I do.

MR: Wow. Good statement. People ask sometimes like when do you know you've made it. But if you're doing what you love and being fairly successful at it—

SB: That'd be the only gauge. Because otherwise you're chasing something that doesn't have any definition. Because even if you've made it in other people's eyes, it may not have been the way that you intended to and so it feels like you missed the mark somehow. So I'm going to try not to ponder when and if I'll ever make it. I mean if I can play a nice chorus of "Cherokee" I've made it for that day.

MR: Yeah, you get one of these from Herb Ellis.

SB: I made it today.

MR: That was one form. Well this has really been fascinating.

SB: It's a pleasure.

MR: I appreciate your coming down and adding to our little archive here of information, because I think you had some really good outlooks on things that I haven't had before.

SB: I'm honored to be a part of it.

MR: Great. Thanks so much.

SB: Thank you, Monk.

MR: Oh you know what? I'm going to edit this out, because I wanted to do something here. I wanted to put on just a bit of this.

[audio interlude]

MR: Was this with the Watrous big band?

SB: Yes. I tried to do something from many different Oscar Peterson projects that I love. And one he did, an album called "Busting Out" with the Ernie Wilkins Big Band, which was a great album. So I thought wouldn't it be fun to do one big band cut. So I wrote this piece, that's the title of the album, based on the Gene Lees book, "The Will to Swing." So this piece is "The Will." And I play with Bill's big band and I know that it doesn't get any better than that. So they came in, they walked in and thirty minutes later they walked out we had an incredible piece of music.

MR: Does that flip you out or what?

SB: Yeah. We had two takes actually. And I could have used either one.

MR: Yeah. Nice.

SB: That's the cats.

MR: Okay, well I'll look forward to checking this whole CD out. And I'll say goodbye again so that we can put it in. So thank you.

SB: Pleasure, Monk.